Password policy: length, complexity and expiry rules

Article KB0010002 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Password reset | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 MacBook Pro/Air, Any device connecting to Acme Global resources via VPN, Wi-Fi, or cloud services, All employee and contractor accounts managed in Microsoft Entra ID (Azure AD) and on-prem Active Directory

Summary

Acme Global enforces a strong password policy to protect corporate accounts: passwords must be at least 14 characters long, expire every 90?days, cannot reuse the last 10 passwords, and trigger a 15-minute lockout after five consecutive failed sign-in attempts. This article explains the policy details, common symptoms users see when the policy blocks access, and provides step-by-step self-help and service-desk procedures for resetting or unlocking a password.

Symptoms

- "Your password has expired and must be changed."
- "Account locked because there have been too many sign-in attempts."
- "Your password doesn't meet the complexity requirements."
- "Unable to sign in to Windows or Company Portal."
- "Did not receive the self-service password reset email or SMS."

Common causes

- Forgotten or mistyped password.
- Password reached its 90-day expiry threshold.
- Account locked out after five failed attempts (lockout lasts 15?minutes).
- New password fails to meet length (>=14 characters) or history (cannot reuse last 10) rules.
- Cached credentials causing stale password prompts after a reset.

Understanding the password policy

Acme Global's password policy is enforced by Microsoft Entra ID and synchronized to on-prem Active Directory. The key rules are:

- Minimum length: 14 characters.
- Complexity: must contain three of four character types (uppercase, lowercase, number, special symbol).
- Expiry: passwords expire every 90?days; users are prompted to change them 14?days before expiry.
- History: the last 10 passwords cannot be reused.
- Lockout: after five consecutive failed sign-in attempts the account is locked for 15?minutes.

These settings apply to Windows login, macOS login via Enterprise Connect, VPN, Wi-Fi (802.1X), and all Microsoft 365 services.

Self-help password reset (SSPR)

If you have forgotten your password, received an expiry notice, or are locked out, you can reset it yourself using the self-service password reset portal. You will need access to your registered authentication method (Microsoft Authenticator app push notification or backup SMS). Ensure you are connected to the internet; if you are off-campus, connect to the VPN first so that the new password can sync to cached credentials.

1. Open a browser and go to https://passwordreset.acme.example.
2. Enter your Acme Global user ID (e.g., jbloggs@acme.example) and click Next.
3. Choose a verification method: approve a push notification in Microsoft Authenticator or enter the code sent via SMS.
4. After verification, you will be prompted to create a new password. Remember:
   - At least 14 characters.
   - Include three of: uppercase, lowercase, number, special symbol.
   - Do not reuse any of your last 10 passwords.
   - Avoid common words or patterns.
5. Type the new password twice, then click Finish.

6. You will see a confirmation that your password has been reset. Close the browser.
7. If you are on a Windows laptop, lock the screen (Win+L) and sign in with the new password to update cached credentials. On macOS, log out and log back in, or run 'dscl . -passwd /Users/username' if prompted.

Service-desk password reset workflow

When a user contacts the Service Desk (phone ext.?4357, Teams channel IT Help, or portal ticket) for a password issue, L1 analysts follow this procedure to verify identity, reset the password, and ensure the user can log in successfully.

1. Greet the user and confirm their identity using at least two of the following: employee ID, date of birth, manager name, or a recent ticket number.
2. Determine the symptom: expired password, lockout, or complexity failure.
3. If the user reports lockout, advise waiting 15?minutes or proceed with reset to clear the lock state immediately.
4. Open the self-service password reset portal on behalf of the user (or use the IAM Temporary Access Pass if the user cannot authenticate).
5. Initiate a password reset:
   - Send a reset link to the user's registered email or phone.
   - Have the user choose a new password that meets the 14-character, complexity, and history rules.
   - Confirm the reset succeeded in the portal.
6. After reset, instruct the user to:
   - On Windows: lock then unlock, or reboot if cached credentials persist.
   - On macOS: log out and back in, or renew the Kerberos ticket via 'kinit' if applicable.
   - If using VPN, disconnect and reconnect so the new password pulls down to the client.
7. Ask the user to test login to a corporate resource (e.g., Outlook via web, Teams, or the Company Portal).
8. Document the reset in the ticket, noting the verification method used and that the user confirmed successful login.

Verification and post-reset checks

Both users and analysts should verify that the new password works everywhere it is needed and that no stale credentials remain. This prevents repeated lockouts and ensures that services like VPN, Wi-Fi, and mapped drives update correctly.

1. Log in to Windows/macOS with the new password and confirm you reach the desktop.
2. Open the Company Portal app and verify that installed applications can sync or update.
3. Connect to the VPN (GlobalProtect) and confirm the connection succeeds without prompting for the old password.
4. If you use Wi-Fi, ensure you are still connected to the ACME-Corp SSID; re-authenticate if prompted.
5. Test access to Outlook on the web and the desktop client to verify mail flow.
6. If any service still asks for the old password, clear saved credentials:
   - Windows: Control Panel -> Credential Manager -> Windows Credentials -> remove entries for 'vpn.acme.example', 'print.acme.example', etc.
   - macOS: Keychain Access -> delete relevant internet or passwords entries.
7. Finally, lock the workstation and sign back in one more time to ensure the credential cache is clean.

Best practices to avoid password issues

Following these habits reduces the likelihood of expiry-related tickets, lockouts, and help-desk calls.

1. Set a calendar reminder 10 days before your password expires (you will receive an email prompt 14 days prior, but a personal reminder helps).
2. Use a passphrase that is easy to remember but meets the 14-character rule, e.g., 'Blue!SkyRiver42!'.
3. Never reuse a password from another personal or corporate account; the history block will prevent reuse of your last 10 Acme passwords anyway.
4. Enable Microsoft Authenticator push notifications as your primary MFA method; keep the backup SMS number up-to-date in the Security Info page.
5. If you anticipate being offline (e.g., travel), connect to VPN before your password expires so the new password can download to cached credentials.
6. Should you be locked out, wait the full 15?minutes before trying again, or contact the Service Desk for an immediate

reset.

When to escalate

If the user cannot complete self-service reset because they lack access to their registered authentication method (no phone, lost Authenticator device, or no backup SMS), the Service Desk L1 agent should escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team. Provide the IAM team with:

- User ID and display name.
- Verification details used (e.g., employee ID, manager confirmation).
- Reason for escalation (missing MFA device, SSPR failure, or temporary access pass required).

The IAM team can issue a Temporary Access Pass or perform an administrative password reset in Entra ID, after which the L1 agent guides the user to set a new password via the portal.

Keywords: password reset, expired password, account lockout, self service password reset, SSPR, password policy, 14 character password, password complexity, password history, lockout 15 minutes, failed login attempts, temporary access pass, identity and access management, IAM, credential manager, cached credentials, VPN password sync